# LICENCE TO KILL

Hunting regulations vary across the globe. In some regions, it is widely permitted; in India, it is entirely banned

## HALFWAY HOME

**● Hunting allowed with strong restrictions**

China, Brazil, Malaysia, Sri Lanka



## NO GUNS ALLOWED

**● Hunting not allowed**

India, some countries in Southeast Asia, Kenya

(Note: Regulations vary even among liberal countries; not an exhaustive list)

## SHOOTER'S ALLEY

**● Countries/ regions with liberal hunting regimes**

Europe, North Asia, Africa, Australia and New Zealand



## NO HUNTING

**"You can't have a halfway house in India. If you permit regulated hunting, you risk losing everything we have gained in terms of conservation because of weak enforcement"**

**DR M.K. RANJITSINH**

*Former member, National Board for Wildlife*

lowed the culling of *nilgai*, Himachal Pradesh of monkeys and Telangana of wild boar. Madhya Pradesh is in the process of drafting a new law to allow the killing of *nilgai* in case of crop damage. Public opinion is divided, with pro-hunting groups saying the process of getting permission is too lengthy and anti-hunting groups calling for even more restrictions.

Some, like ecologist and professor Madhav Gadgil, have called for an overall withdrawal of the WPA. "The WPA is anti-people, anti-science and has been used to harass people," he says. He adds a legal rationale for the right to hunt: "The Indian Penal Code allows for the use of force against human beings in cases of bodily harm or loss of property," he says. "There is no reason why farmers should not be allowed to similarly protect their crops from animals. That the WPA prevents farmers from doing so is unconstitutional." However, he adds that he does not support hunting for sport.

"Hunting, in the commercial sense, doesn't fit into the Indian ethos," says Vivek Menon, executive director and founder of the Wildlife Trust of India. "Culturally, we are different from the countries that allow hunting." He also highlights the point about lax enforcement, saying, "In a vast country like India, regulating commercial hunting could become a monitoring nightmare." However, he also believes that farmers should have the right to protect their crops from wild animals. "The government needs to address this problem," he says.

Environmental lawyer Ritwik Dutta says that culls are not the only solution to such conflicts. "Fencing is a viable option that the state needs to invest in," he says. He argues against any legalisation of hunting, specifically commercial trophy hunting, and says the Indian and African experiences cannot be compared. "African countries have smaller populations, which allows them to reserve large areas for wildlife. In India, only three per cent of the area has been marked off for wildlife." He also opposes the hunting-for-revenue model, saying, "The funds for wildlife need not come through killing."

For now, the proposed amendments are being reviewed by a parliamentary standing committee on science and technology, environment, forests and climate change. Even if passed, they will not overturn the overall ban on hunting in India, but many remain alarmed at the prospect of any weakening of protections. The proposals also include enhanced punishments for wildlife crimes, a rationalisation of the schedules of protected species and provisions relating to international norms on the trade of endangered species. Many describe this latest amendment as being the most sweeping of all the changes the WPA has seen since 1972. Whether it improves or worsens matters for India's wildlife is open to a wild guess. ■